PUNJABI COLLECTION

NO. 04



RURAL PUNJAB ORIGIN

# Sarson da Saag

Slow-Cooked Mustard Greens Curry
Punjab's Winter Harvest Centerpiece

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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ABOUT THIS BOOK

# Sarson da Saag

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DISCLAIMER

Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.



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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

# The Dish That Defines a Punjabi Winter

Sarson da saag is as deeply rooted in Punjab's agricultural calendar as any dish in Indian cuisine. Mustard greens (sarson) are a winter crop, planted after the monsoon and harvested through the coldest months, and for generations of Punjabi farming families, this saag — slow-cooked mustard greens blended with other winter greens and simmered for hours — has marked the arrival of the season as reliably as any calendar.

Its inseparable partner is makki di roti, cornmeal flatbread, and the pairing together has become such a cultural touchstone that in much of Punjab, simply mentioning "saag" is understood to mean this entire meal. The dish is closely tied to Lohri, the January harvest festival, when families gather to celebrate the winter crop with exactly this meal.

Traditionally made in large batches and slow-cooked for hours — sometimes even simmered gently overnight — sarson da saag rewards patience above all else. The greens break down completely into a thick, deeply savory puree that bears little resemblance to a quick sauté, and that long cooking time is precisely what built its reputation as a labor-of-love dish, historically prepared by families together rather than rushed through on a weeknight.



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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

# The Dish That Defines a Punjabi Winter, continued

### CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

Deeply tied to Punjab's mustard harvest season and the Lohri festival celebrated every January. Traditionally eaten with makki di roti — the two are considered culturally inseparable. Historically a labor-intensive, slow-cooked dish prepared in large batches for family gatherings. A defining symbol of rural Punjabi winter life and hospitality, often served to guests as a point of pride.



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AT A GLANCE

# Equipment & preparation

| 20m | 1.5–3h | 4 | Med |
|---|---|---|---|
| ACTIVE PREP | SIMMER TIME | SERVINGS | DIFFICULTY |

## Recommended equipment

- Large, heavy-bottomed pot
- Hand blender or masher (traditionally, a wooden ghotni/madhani is used for a rustic texture)
- Kadai or pan for the tempering
- Wooden spoon for frequent stirring

### STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Sarson da saag keeps refrigerated for up to 4 days and, like many slow-cooked greens dishes, tastes even better reheated the next day. It freezes very well for up to 3 months — a genuinely practical make-ahead dish given its long cooking time. Reheat gently with a little water or extra butter to restore its rich consistency.



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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

# Ingredients

## For the greens

| INGREDIENT | US | METRIC | INDIAN |
|---|---|---|---|
| Mustard greens (sarson), chopped | 1 lb | 450 g | 1 large bunch |
| Spinach (palak), chopped | ½ lb | 225 g | 1 small bunch |
| Bathua or extra spinach, chopped — optional | ¼ lb | 115 g | handful |
| Green chili | 2 | 2 | 2 |
| Ginger, roughly chopped | 1 inch | 10 g | 1 inch |
| Water | 1½ cups | 360 ml | 1½ katori |
| Salt | 1 tsp | 6 g | to taste |

## For the tempering (tadka)

| INGREDIENT | US | METRIC | INDIAN |
|---|---|---|---|
| Ghee or butter | 3 tbsp | 45 g | 3 chammach |
| Onion, finely chopped | 1 medium | 100 g | 1 medium |
| Garlic, minced | 4–5 cloves | 15 g | 4–5 cloves |
| Tomato, finely chopped | 1 medium | 100 g | 1 medium |
| Red chili powder | ½ tsp | 1.5 g | ½ chammach |
| Makki ka atta (corn flour), for thickening | 2 tbsp | 15 g | 2 tbsp |



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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

# Ingredients, continued

### SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Fresh mustard greens can be found at South Asian grocers, and increasingly at farmers markets and specialty produce sections in the US and UK — look for "mustard greens" or "sarson." If unavailable, a blend of collard greens and spinach approximates the flavor, though the distinctive mustard bite will be milder. Bathua (a wild green traditionally used) is optional and hard to find outside India; simply increase the spinach quantity if you can't source it.



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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

# Cooking the Greens

## 01 SIMMER THE GREENS

Combine the mustard greens, spinach, bathua if using, green chili, ginger, water, and salt in a large pot. Bring to a boil, then reduce heat and simmer, covered, for 1–2 hours, stirring occasionally, until the greens are completely soft and reduced.

## 02 MASH TO A COARSE PUREE

Once cooked, mash the greens directly in the pot using a hand blender or traditional wooden masher, pulsing just until you reach a coarse, slightly textured puree — sarson da saag is traditionally rustic, not perfectly smooth.



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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

## Cooking the Greens, continued



**Chef tip.** resist the urge to blend it completely smooth in a countertop blender — the slightly coarse, rustic texture is part of what makes this dish authentic.

COOKING CHECKPOINT

The greens are ready to mash once they've completely collapsed and softened, with no firm stems remaining and the water mostly absorbed into a thick, wilted mass.



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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

# The Tempering & Final Simmer

## 03 SAUTÉ THE AROMATICS

Heat ghee in a kadai and sauté the chopped onion until golden, about 6–8 minutes. Add the garlic and cook until fragrant, then add the tomato and red chili powder, cooking until the tomato softens and the oil separates slightly.

## 04 COMBINE WITH THE GREENS

Stir the tempering into the pot of mashed greens, mixing thoroughly. Sprinkle in the corn flour, stirring continuously to avoid lumps — this is the traditional thickener used in place of cream.



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# The Tempering & Final Simmer, continued



## 05 SIMMER TO FINISH

Simmer together for another 20–30 minutes on low heat, stirring occasionally, until the saag thickens further and the flavors meld completely.

**Texture indicator.** finished saag should be thick enough to hold a spoon standing upright, not thin or watery.



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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

## The Tempering & Final Simmer, continued

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Rushing the initial simmer of the greens is the most common mistake — undercooked greens leave the saag tasting sharp and grassy rather than deep and mellow. Give the greens their full simmering time before mashing.



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SERVING & PAIRING

# How to serve



## Traditional Style

- Served hot with makki di roti and a generous pool of white butter melting in the center of the saag.
- Often served with a piece of jaggery on the side, for the classic sweet-savory Punjabi winter pairing.



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# How to serve, continued

## Restaurant Presentation

- Served in a bowl with a visible well of ghee or butter in the middle, alongside a stack of makki di roti.

## Family Style

- A large shared pot at the center of a winter family gathering, exactly as it's traditionally served at Lohri.



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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

# Chef secrets

## Getting the Depth Right

- A long, slow simmer genuinely can't be rushed — this is a dish where more time reliably means more flavor.
- Corn flour is the traditional thickener, giving the saag a slightly different character than cream would — don't substitute cream if you want the authentic flavor.

## Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- Sarson da saag is one of the best make-ahead dishes in Punjabi cuisine — cook a large batch and freeze in portions.
- The flavor deepens over a day or two in the refrigerator, so don't hesitate to make it well ahead of when you plan to serve it.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Some cooks add a small piece of maize cob directly to the simmering greens for extra body and a subtle sweetness, removing it before mashing — an old farmhouse trick worth trying.



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BONUS CONTENT

# Nutrition, variations & FAQ

## APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

| 165 kcal | 6 g | 14 g | 10 g | 6 g |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| CALORIES | PROTEIN | CARBOHYDRATES | FAT | FIBER |

Estimates only; actual values vary with cream, butter, and portion size.

### ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Dairy, Gluten, Mustard. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

## REGIONAL VARIATIONS

| | |
|---|---|
| **Saag with Paneer** | cubes of paneer folded in during the final simmer, a popular modern addition. |
| **Restaurant-Style Saag** | often pureed smoother and enriched with extra cream for a milder, more refined texture. |
| **Punjabi Farmhouse Saag** | the most rustic version, left coarsely mashed and made with whatever winter greens are available. |

## Can I make this with frozen greens?

Yes — frozen mustard greens and spinach work well and can save significant prep time, though fresh greens give the best flavor if available.



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# Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

## Why does my saag taste bitter?

Mustard greens have a natural bitterness that mellows significantly with long cooking. If it still tastes sharp, it likely needs more simmering time.

## Can I make this vegan?

Yes — substitute the ghee and butter with a neutral oil and plant-based butter; the dish remains delicious, if slightly less rich.



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REFERENCE

# Ingredient glossary





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REFERENCE

# Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

| | |
|---|---|
| **Sarson** | Punjabi/Hindi for mustard greens, the defining ingredient of this dish. |
| **Bathua** | a wild winter green traditionally added to saag for extra depth. |
| **Makki di Roti** | cornmeal flatbread, the traditional and essential pairing for this dish. |
| **Lohri** | a Punjabi harvest festival celebrated every January, closely tied to this meal. |



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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

# Sarson da Saag

| 20m | 1.5–3h |
|---|---|
| ACTIVE PREP | SIMMER TIME |
| **4** | **Med** |
| SERVINGS | DIFFICULTY |

## GREENS

| | |
|---|---|
| Mustard greens | 450 g |
| Spinach | 225 g |
| Bathua or extra spinach | 115 g |
| Green chili | 2 |
| Ginger | 10 g |
| Water | 360 ml |
| Salt | 6 g |

## TEMPERING (TADKA)

| | |
|---|---|
| Ghee or butter | 45 g |
| Onion | 100 g |
| Garlic | 15 g |
| Tomato | 100 g |
| Red chili powder | 1.5 g |
| Makki ka atta | 15 g |

## METHOD

01 **Simmer the greens.** Combine the mustard greens, spinach, bathua if using, green chili, ginger, water, and salt in a large pot.

02 **Mash to a coarse puree.** Once cooked, mash the greens directly in the pot using a hand blender or traditional wooden masher, pulsing just until you reach a coarse, slightly textured puree — sarson da saag is traditionally rustic, not perfectly smooth.

03 **Sauté the aromatics.** Heat ghee in a kadai and sauté the chopped onion until golden, about 6–8 minutes.

04 **Combine with the greens.** Stir the tempering into the pot of mashed greens, mixing thoroughly.

05 **Simmer to finish.** Simmer together for another 20–30 minutes on low heat, stirring occasionally, until the saag thickens further and the flavors meld completely.



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BEFORE YOU SHOP

# Shopping list

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| ☐ Mustard greens | 450 g | ☐ Spinach | 225 g |
| ☐ Bathua or extra spinach | 115 g | ☐ Green chili | 2 |
| ☐ Ginger | 10 g | ☐ Salt | 6 g |
| ☐ Ghee or butter | 45 g | ☐ Onion | 100 g |
| ☐ Garlic | 15 g | ☐ Tomato | 100 g |
| ☐ Red chili powder | 1.5 g | ☐ Makki ka atta | 15 g |



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